

Sennheiser PXC 450

Noise out, sound in!

The PXC 450 is the latest from Sennheiser's travel line of headphones. "Portable" and "circumaural" generally don't see eye to eye due to bulk and issues with anchoring them to your head. To remedy this, the PXC 450 has a very firm headband; thankfully, it's padded and well-designed enough to not squash your ears.

The patented active noise cancellation technology called NoiseGard 2.0 makes its presence felt. This uses a combination of improved circuitry (over the previous version of NoiseGard), and better microphones (that detect unwanted outside noise). Their noise elimination algorithms have also seen an overhaul. Using NoiseGard will require a single AAA battery. Remove the battery and the PXC 450 can function as a regular, wired headphone set.

There's a talk-through function inbuilt. According to Sennheiser, two microphones (one on each

cup) pick up external sounds in the immediate vicinity such as someone trying to talk to you. We tested this feature, but it didn't work too well, and the reviewer had to take off the headphones to hear what the other person was saying. Nevertheless the PXC 450 isolates noise beautifully even with NoiseGard off.

Bass is quite a mixed bag: sometimes it's there and goes quite low, on other tracks it's not as pronounced as the mids and highs. We'd have liked for these phones to be a little kinder to vocals and mids—which, although forward (not overly so), lack finer detail. (At this point we're comparing them to audiophile-grade cans.)

Their quick response means the PXC 450 is equally suited for fast heavy metal

music as to country or soft rock genres. They're rather easy to drive—so using them with your iPod while aboard a noisy local or bus is a possibility.

These cans need to be used for around a hundred hours before they actually sound good (burned in, if you will). We found a full 35 to 40 per cent difference in

quality and bass reproduction, and highs became a little more noticeable. They're still improving after the 120 odd hours that we've spent with them, so don't go by the way a brand new pair sounds.

At Rs 29,900, the PXC 450 is far from affordable. Even if you can foot the bill, you will still need to accept that these aren't the audiophile-grade cans that the price suggests. That said, they're head and shoulder above most other headphones available in India, and definitely one of the best noise-cancelling sets we've come across (including the Bose Companion 5). Of course they're in a price league of their own!

Specifications

8 to 28000 Hz; 150 ohms; Sound Pressure Level (SPL): 108 dB; Cable: 1.4 m; Weight: 240g; Accessories: transport case, 6.3 mm stereo adapter

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Price: Rs 29,900



RATINGS

Features	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★☆☆
Comfort	★★★★☆
Overall	★★★★☆

Buffalo DriveStation TurboUSB 250GB (HD-HS250U2)

Turbocharged Transfers

The TurboUSB feature incorporated on the Buffalo HD-HS250U2 external hard drive promises a 37 per cent improvement in transfer speeds over regular PATA-based external USB drives.

The drive is well built with matte-black plastic edges. The bottom half of the silver coloured side panel and the top panel have pores to aid air circulation. Additionally, you can improve the drive's cooling by clipping the optional HD-HSU2 fan to the top of the drive.

The drive automatically powers itself down when it detects a disconnection from the host PC, or when the PC shuts down. It enters a state of hibernation when

inactive for a preset amount of time. The bundled Secure Lock Ware allows AES 256/128 encryption of important data, preventing unauthorised access. Then, Memeo AutoBackup is a feature-rich and simple-to-use software—it allows you to back up to a shared network device, network folder, iPod, Memeo Internet drive, or Flash drive.

The tests were performed in both normal and TurboUSB mode. In the latter, the drive outper-

formed the Digit Best Buy June 2007 Western Digital MyBook Essential (500 GB). Switching between Turbo and normal mode is easy using the TurboUSB utility.

The drive is definitely not the cheapest amongst the 250 GB drives available, though the performance in TurboUSB mode justifies the cost to an extent. Power management, along with the option for additional cooling, makes it a good purchase if you're looking for a dedicated external drive.



RATINGS

Features	★★★★☆
Performance	★★★★☆
Build Quality	★★★★☆
Value for Money	★★★☆☆
Overall	★★★★☆

Specifications

7200 rpm SATA; USB 2.0; TurboUSB; Dimensions: 4.6 (W) x 16.3 (D) x 20(H) cm; Weight: 6.2 kg

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Price: Rs 7,800